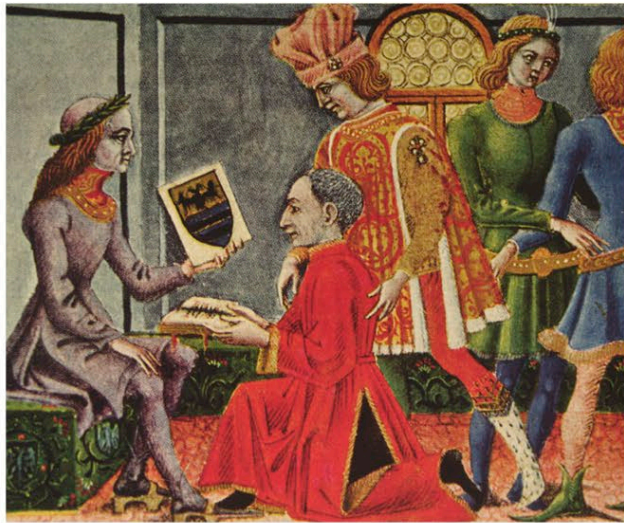


LOOKING TO THE STARS

Western astrology



▲ Royal patronage

The astronomer Giovanni Bianchini (kneeling) presents his *Tabulae Astronomiae* to the Holy Roman Emperor Frederick III. First compiled in 1442, his work provided more accurate measurements of the locations of planets and stars than before, which were an invaluable source for astrologers.

Astrology, the belief that movements of the stars and planets influenced human lives and events on earth, had its origins in Babylonia. In Renaissance Europe, translations of ancient texts increased interest in astrology at the same time as a new discipline emerged: astronomy—the scientific study of the universe and of objects in space without reference to humans. The two disciplines were often thought complementary at the time.

The 1st century CE Greco-Roman Ptolemy set out his astrological system, known as the Ptolemaic system, in the *Tetrabiblos*. This system was used by Renaissance astrologers such as Italian Luca Gaurico, who drew on it to publish birth horoscope charts of leading figures in his 1552 work, *Tractatus Astrologicus*. Astrologers benefitted, too, from patrons such as Pope Leo X and Queen Elizabeth I, who enlisted the services of the polymath John Dee to advise on the best date for her coronation.

Rise and fall of astrology

Renaissance astrology influenced other disciplines, too. Humanist Marsilio Ficino argued that the physical and spiritual well-being of humans could be harmonized with the heavenly order in *Liber de Vita*. Danish astronomer Tycho Brahe believed in astrology, too—when he observed a “new star” in 1572 (in reality a supernova) he interpreted it in the light of human events as an omen of war and

famine, while astrologers used the increased accuracy of celestial measurements, made newly possible by astronomy, to refine their systems.

By 1647, English astrologer William Lilly, in his *Christian Astrology*, revealed many correspondences linking astral objects to matters on earth; for example, that the planet Jupiter was related to modesty, justice, a clear complexion, cloves, pears, elephants, unicorns, and the number three. For all that, astrology was by then in decline. A papal decree of 1586 banned magical practices and astrology, and 17th-century scientists increasingly rejected anything to do with magic, including reading the stars.

► Merchants guided by the planet Jupiter

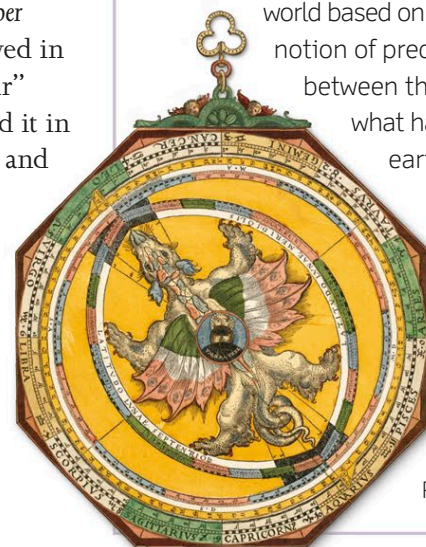
In astrology, planets controlled particular areas of life, and Leonardo Dati's *De Sphaera* (1470) shows Jupiter exerting a benign influence on bakers, grain-sellers, and fishmongers.

IN CONTEXT

New science

The Enlightenment weakened the hold of astrology on science. Sir Isaac Newton (despite being a keen alchemist) formulated the theory of gravity and swung scholarly opinion away from Ptolemaic cosmology (that the earth was stationary and at the center of the universe) to a view of the world based on science. The astrological notion of predictable relationships between the stars and planets and what happened to people on earth was replaced with a belief that the universe operated according to a set of fixed scientific laws.

This illustration is from Peter Apian's 1540 *Astronomicum Caesareum*, a work of Ptolemaic astrology.



“Wisest prince, you are not unfamiliar with how profitable astrology is to men.”

GIOVANNI BIANCHINI, *TABULAE ASTRONOMIAE*, 1400s